

**BALANCING THE EQUATION;
HOW ACADEMIC AND SOFT SKILLS PREDICT CAREER OUTCOME**

**BY
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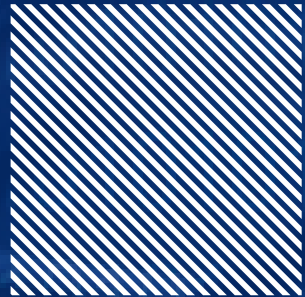
A woman with blonde hair, wearing a white blazer over a black dress and a pearl necklace, is smiling and gesturing with her hands while speaking on a stage. Behind her is a large screen displaying the word "Introduction". An audience of people is seated in the background, looking towards the speaker.

Introduction

INTRODUCTION

- This project was born out of a concern I've carried for a while. I have friends who graduated top of their class — brilliant minds, celebrated for their academic excellence. Yet, after school, they faced the harsh reality that good grades alone didn't translate to career success. Many struggled to find jobs, some fell into depression, and others simply faded into the background despite their potential.
- That personal experience left a big question on my mind:
- 'What really determines success after school? Is academic performance enough, or are there other forces at play?

Dataset Overview



The dataset was from Kaggle educational datasets. This dataset explores the relationship between academics performance and career success. It includes 5000 records of students' educational backgrounds, skills and career outcomes'

It contains 20 columns which is being categorize into 4 namely;

- Academic Performance
- Career Readiness
- Career Outcome
- Work-life Balance

Each having a unique identifier called 'student_id' linking all the segments.

Problem Statement

While academic excellence is often seen as a predictor of success, many high-performing graduates struggle with employment, career satisfaction, and personal stability after school. This raises critical concerns:

- What role do non-academic factors like career readiness, internships, and work-life balance play in career outcomes?
- Is there a disconnect between academic achievement and real-world employability?
- How well are students being prepared for life beyond school?

This analysis aims to examine these questions using real-world data, and provide insights that can inform educators, students, and policymakers alike.

Research Questions

Academic Success

1. What is the average university GPA of students based on their field of study?
2. How does SAT score correlate with university GPA?
3. What percentage of students attended a top 100 ranked university?

Career Success

7. What is the average starting salary based on
8. What is the average number of years to first promotion?
9. What is the career satisfaction level across different job levels?
10. What percentage of students transition into entrepreneurship?

Career Readiness

4. How many internships and projects do students complete on average before graduation?
5. What is the impact of certifications on job offers received?
6. Does a higher networking score lead to more job offers?

Work-Life Balance

11. Is there a relationship between work-life balance and career satisfaction?
12. Do students with higher soft skills scores report better work-life balance?
field of study?

METHODOLOGY

Data Cleaning and Transformation
Tools Used Techniques

- Excel Data Model (Power pivot) used to connect multiple tables via relationships. It also allowed me to build a relational structure without merging all the data in a single table.

- Power Query

for filtering and loading data into the model.

- Slicers and Relationships

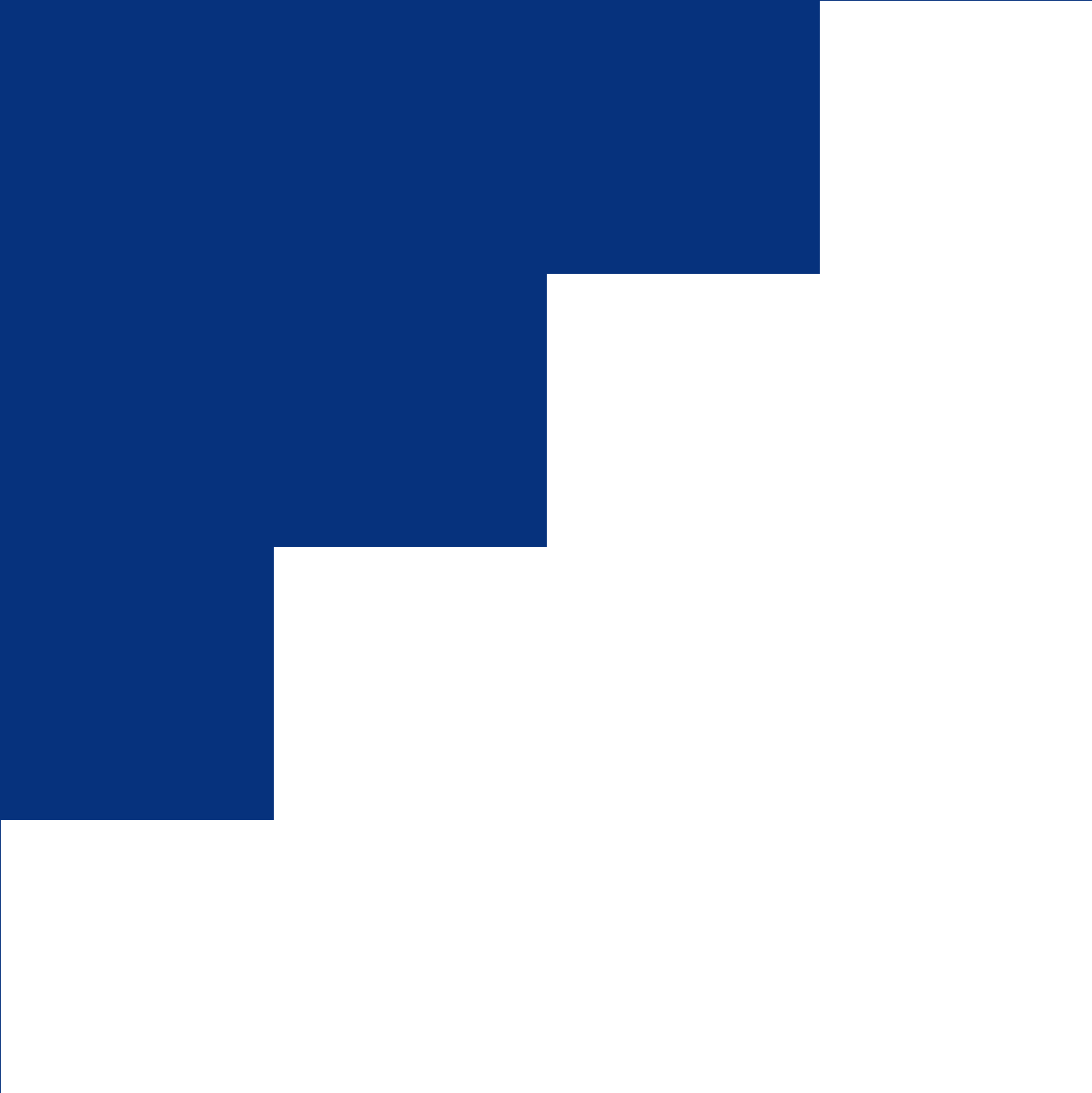
implemented to allow dynamic filtering and to observe interdependence data across visuals

- PowerPoint (Shapes & Fragmentation)

Created custom buttons and navigational shapes using PowerPoint's shape and merge features'

- Excel Hyperlinks

Linked shapes to individual Dashboard across worksheets, enabling smooth navigation and a better user experience.



Dashboard walkthrough

Education and career success

- Academics Performance
- Career Readiness
- Career Outcome
- Work-life Balance

ACADEMIC PERFORMANCE KPIs and CHARTS



KPIs

AVG University GPA

3.02

Avg university GPA according to field of study shows student's average performance

AVG SAT Score

1253.83

AVG SAT Score by field of study shows the AVG of each university satisfactory scores

AVG High School GPA

3.00

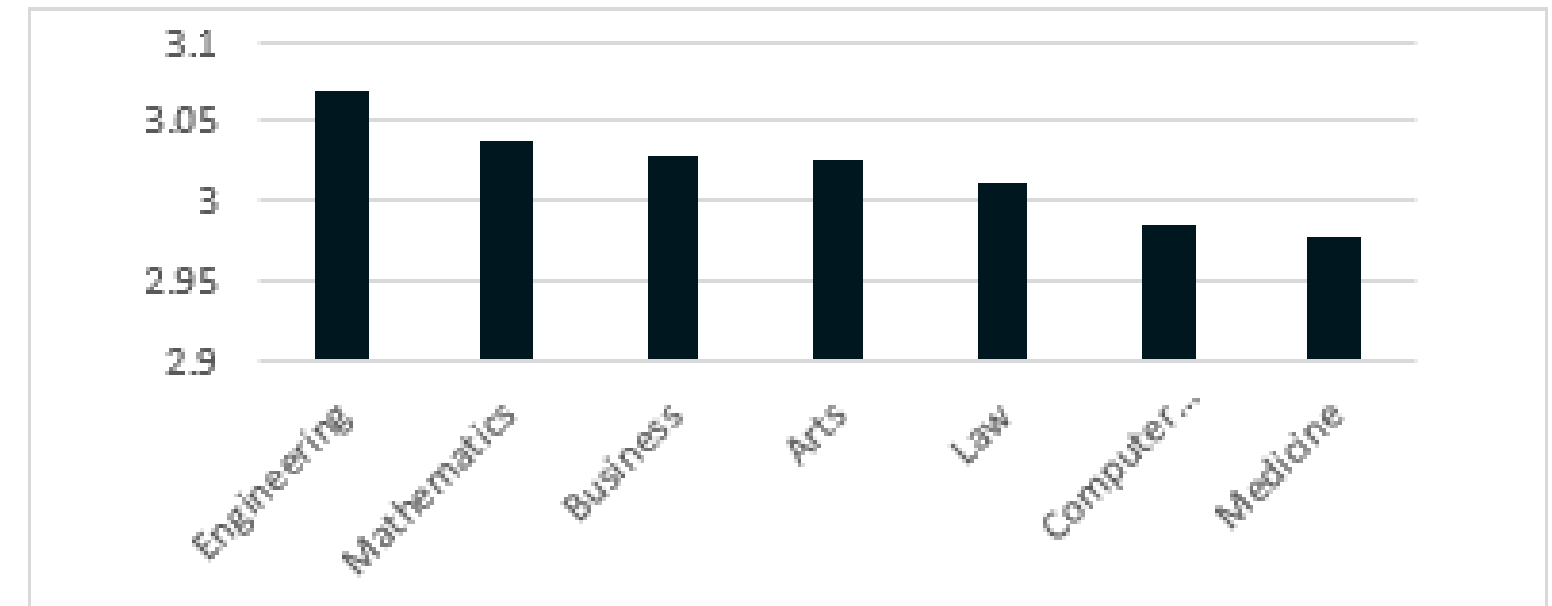
AVG High school GPA according to field of study shows student's average performance

Academic Performance Base on Field of study

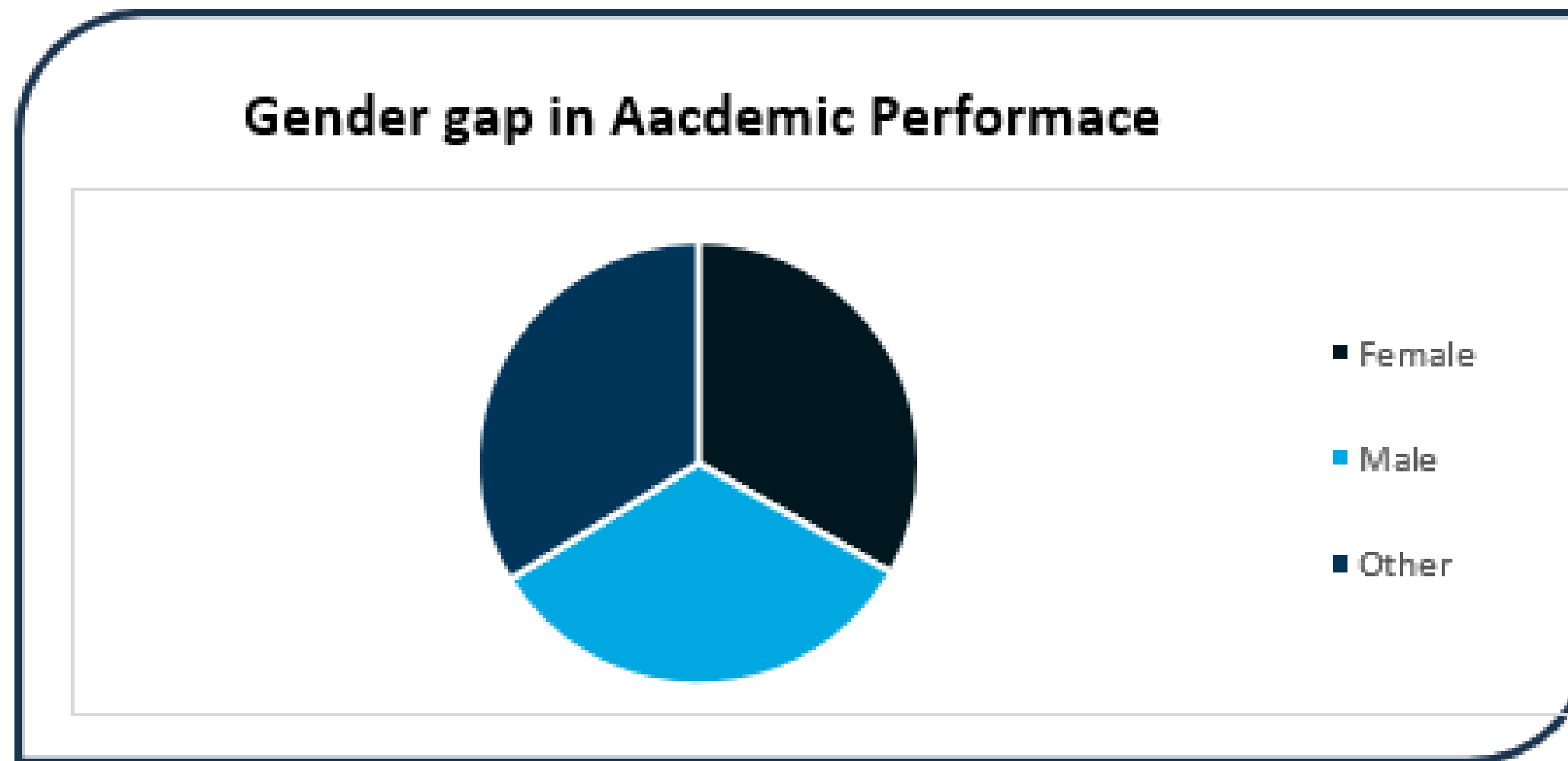
The chart shows that "Engineering" has the highest GPA (just over 3.05).

Note: Interestingly, Engineering appears to be the field of study where students achieved the highest average GPA in university

Field of Study with the Highest GPA



Academic Performance Base on Gender



- Visual: Pie chart showing a breakdown of "Female," "Male," and "Other" in "Academic Performance." The chart shows a larger blue segment (presumably one gender) and a smaller teal segment (another gender), with a very small grey slice for "Other."
- Note: This chart highlights the gender distribution within the academic performance data. Further analysis could explore if there are significant differences in outcomes between these groups.

CAREER READINESS KPIs AND CHARTS



KPIs

**Average No of Int.
Completed**

1.98

**AVG NO. Project
Completd**

4.56

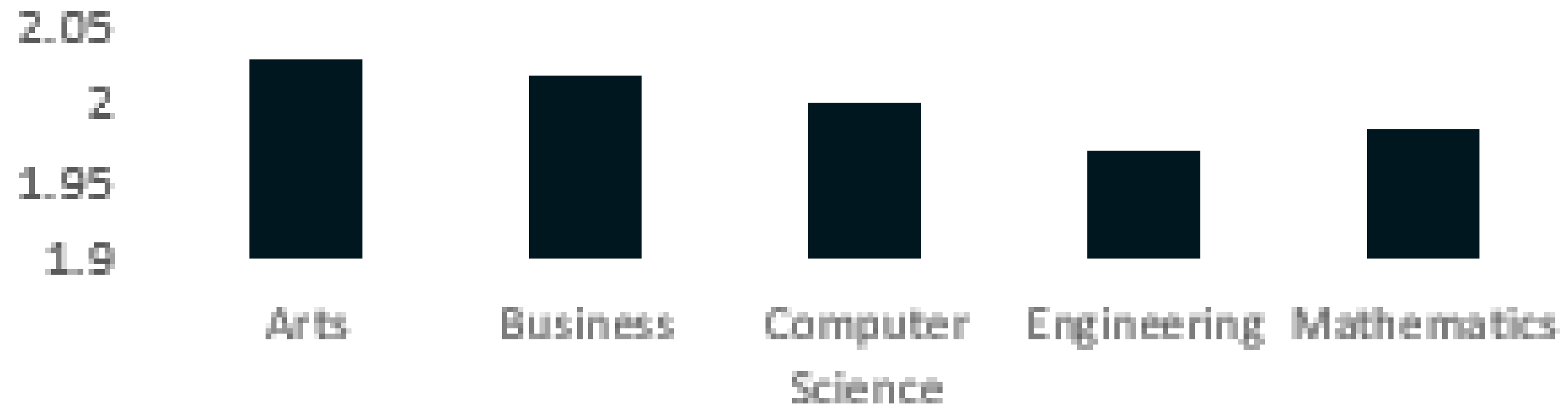
AVG Soft Skills

5.55

AVG Net. Scores

5.54

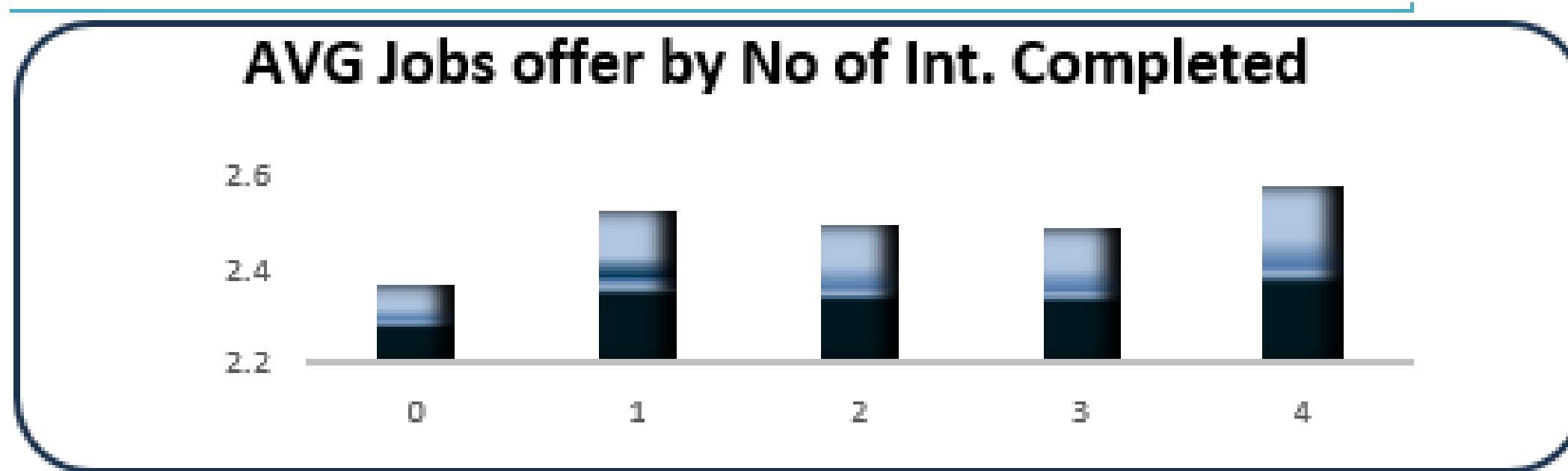
Top 5 Field of Study with Most Internship



FIELD OF STUDIES WITH THE HIGHEST INTERNSHIP

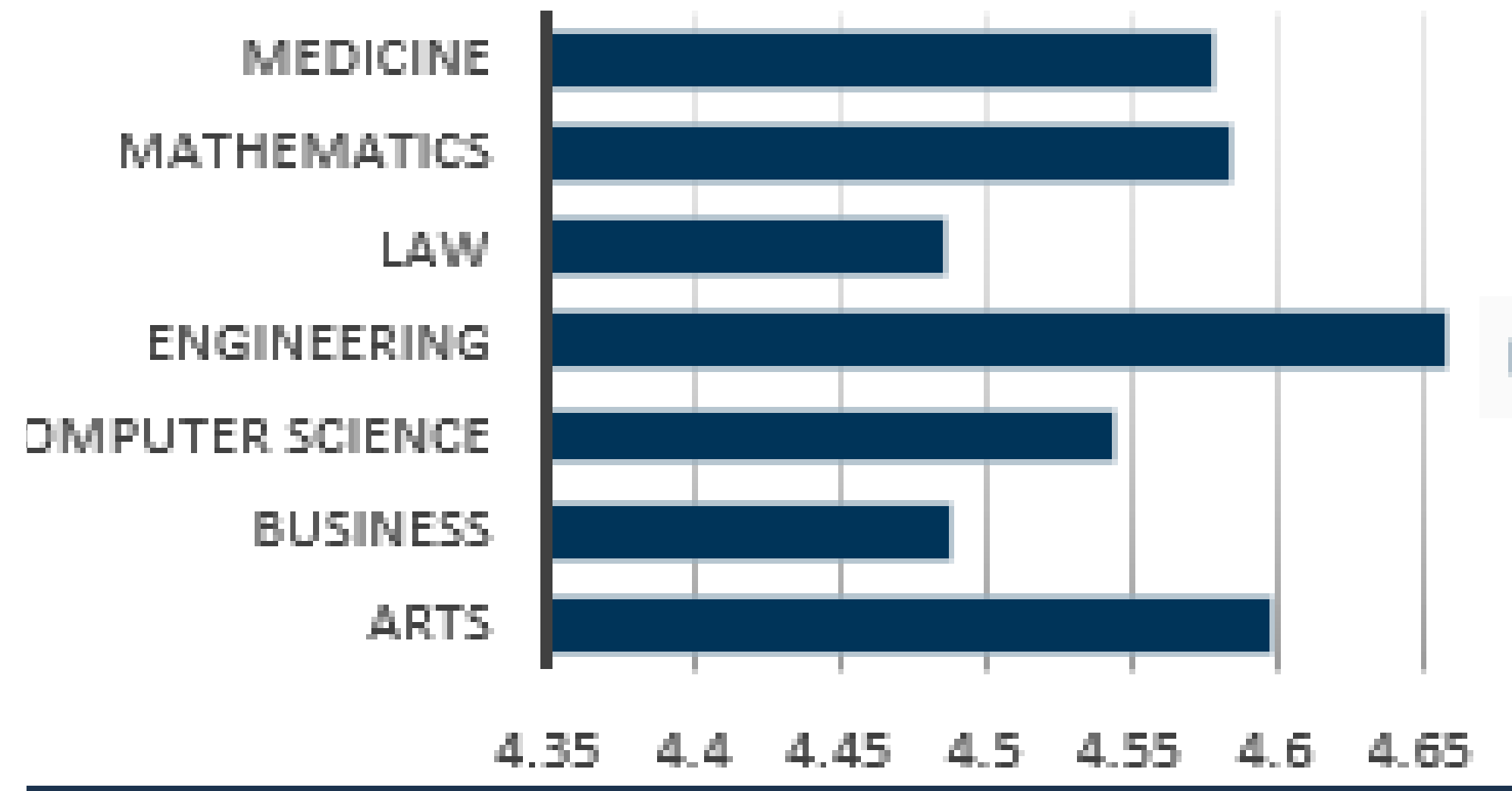
- Visual: Bar chart showing "Arts" having the highest average number of internships (around 1.98), followed by Business, Computer Science, Engineering, and Mathematics Science.
- Note: When it comes to gaining practical experience through internships, Arts students in this dataset seem to have engaged the most.

Jobs Offer by No. of Internship Completed



- Visual: Stacked bar chart showing the average number of job offers received based on the number of internships completed (0 to 4). The chart suggests a positive trend, with more job offers on average for those with more internships.
- Note: There's a clear indication here that completing more internships correlates with a higher average number of job offers received. Practical experience seems to be a significant advantage

Field of Study with Highest Project



No. of Project According to Field

- Visual: Horizontal bar chart showing "Engineering" having the highest total number of projects, followed by Law, Mathematics, Medicine, Computer Science, Business, and Arts.
- Note: Engineering students appear to have been involved in the highest number of projects across all fields of study. This could reflect the project-based nature of the discipline

Correletion between Certification and other key component in Career Readiness

- Visual: Heatmap showing correlations between "Certification," "Average Soft Skills," "Average Networking Score," and "Average No. of Internship." There seems to be a moderate positive correlation between "Certification" and both "Average Soft Skills" and "Average Networking Score." "Average No. of Internship" also shows positive correlations with "Average Soft Skills" and "Average Networking Score."
- Note: This correlation matrix suggests that obtaining certifications might be linked to stronger soft skills and networking abilities, which are crucial for career readiness. Similarly, more internships also seem to contribute positively to these areas

CORR	Certificati	Average of interst	Average of proj	Average of soft skil	Average of Networking score
Certificati	1.000	0.089	0.082	0.268	0.506
Average o	0.089	1.000	-0.471	0.467	0.514
Average c	0.082	-0.471	1.000	0.532	-0.288
Average o	0.268	0.467	0.532	1.000	0.271
Average o	0.506	0.514	-0.288	0.271	1.000

Career Outcome KPIs and Charts





KPIs

2.49

\$50,564

**AVG NO. of
Job Offers**

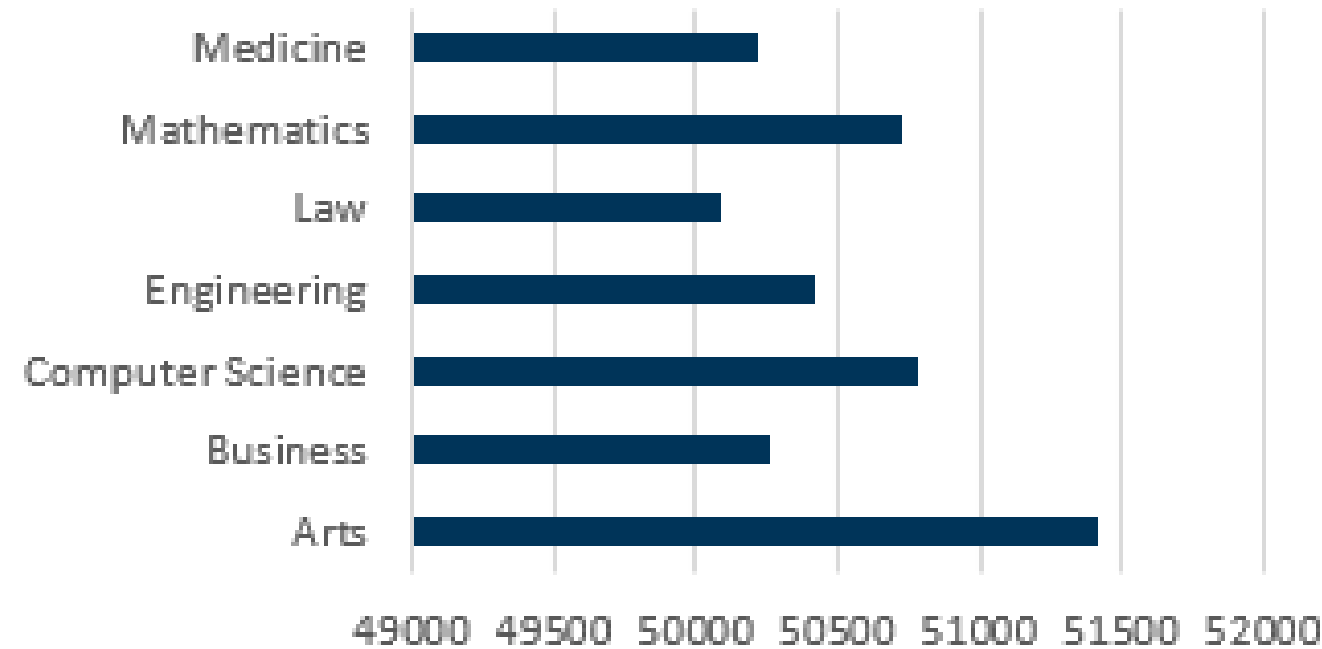
**AVG Starting
Salary**

AVG NO. of Job Offers: 2.49", "AVG Starting Salary:
\$50,564"

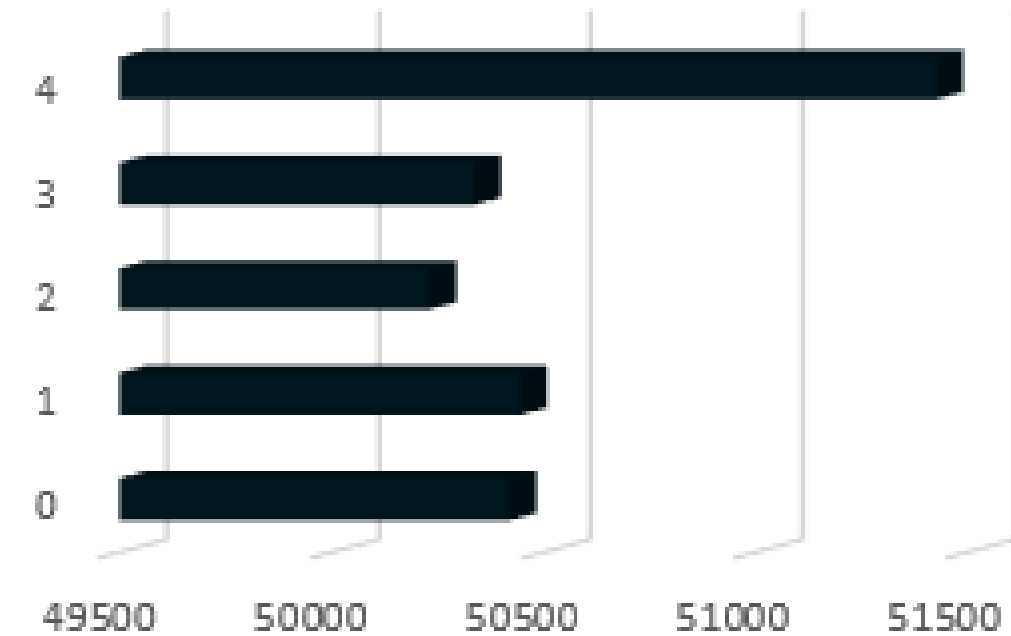
AVG NO. of Job Offers: 2.49", "AVG Starting Salary:
\$50,564"

Salary, Internship completed and feild of study

FIELD OF STUDY WITH THE HIGHEST SALARY



SALARY BASE ON No. OF INTERNSHIP COMP.



- Visuals: Bar chart showing "Field of Study with the Highest Salary" (Medicine), and "Salary Base on No. of Internship Comp."
- Note: On average, individuals in this dataset received approximately 2.49 job offers with a starting salary of \$50,564. Medicine is the field of study with the highest salary. There's also a positive correlation between the number of internships completed and the starting salary



Work-life Balance KPIs and Charts

KPIs

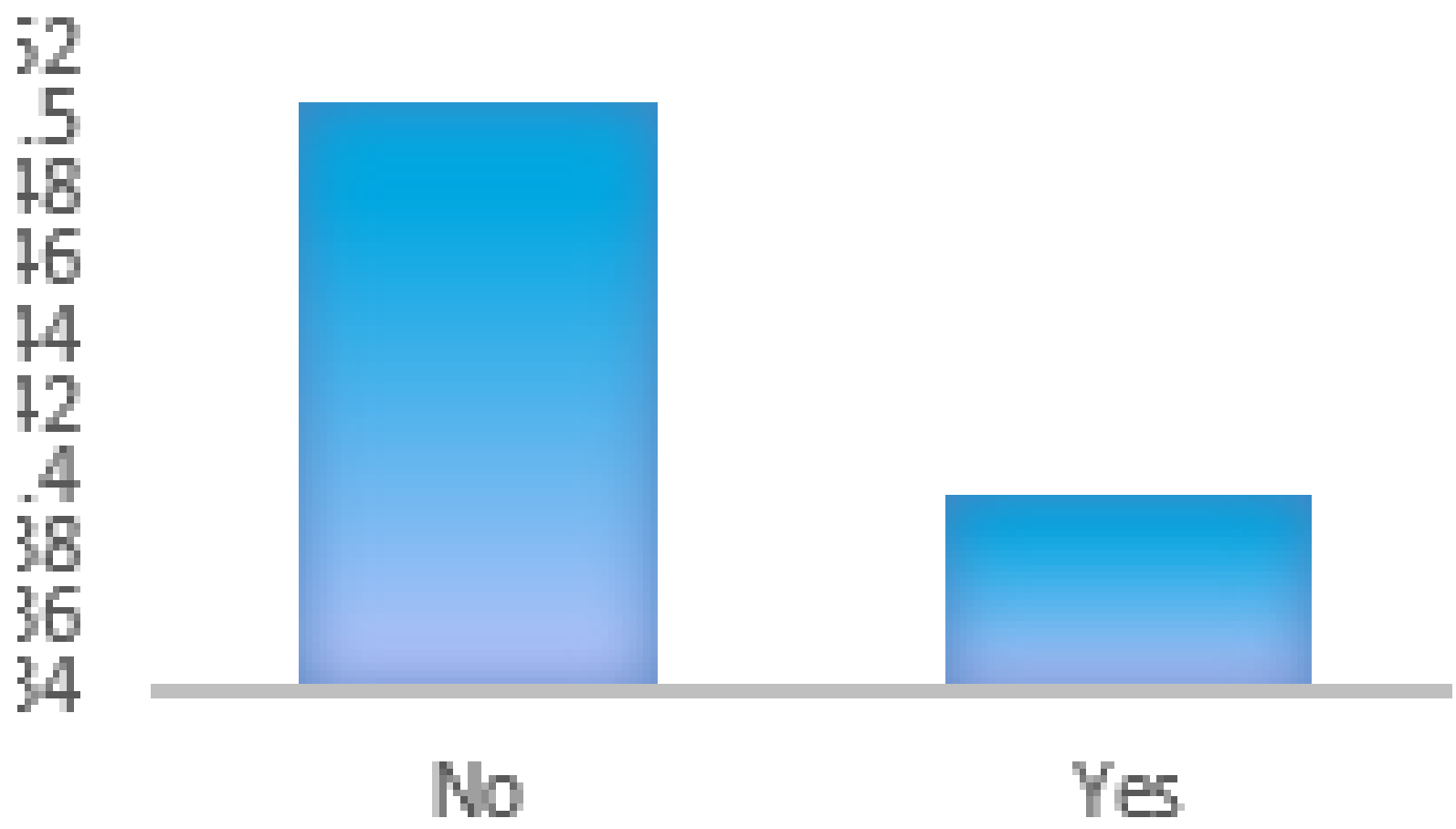
Average work Life

5.48

% of Students
Became Entreprnuer

20%

Entrepreneurs & Work_Life Balance

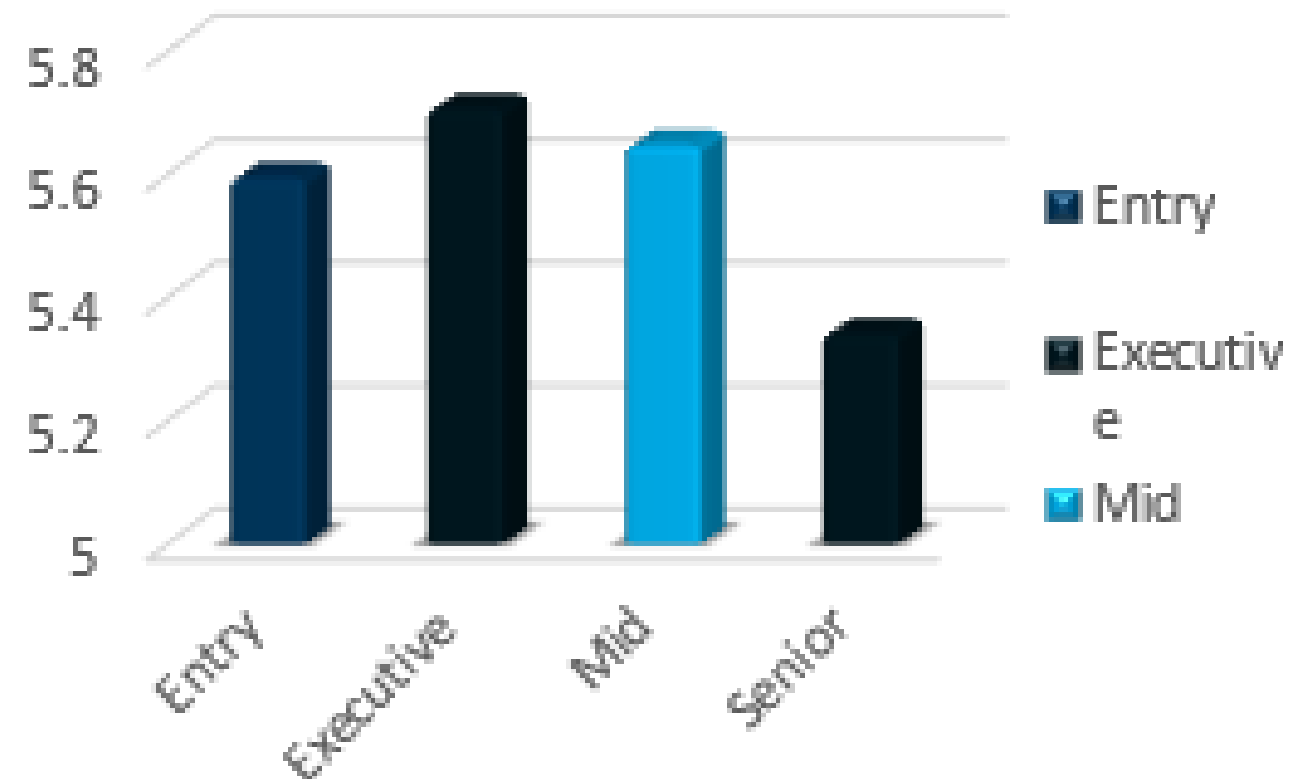


Entrepreneurship Status and work-life Balance

- The bar with the NO represents non-Entrepreneurs. while the bar with the YES represents Entrepreneurs.
- Most students who become entrepreneurs don't seem to have a work-life balance

Career satisfaction & Job level

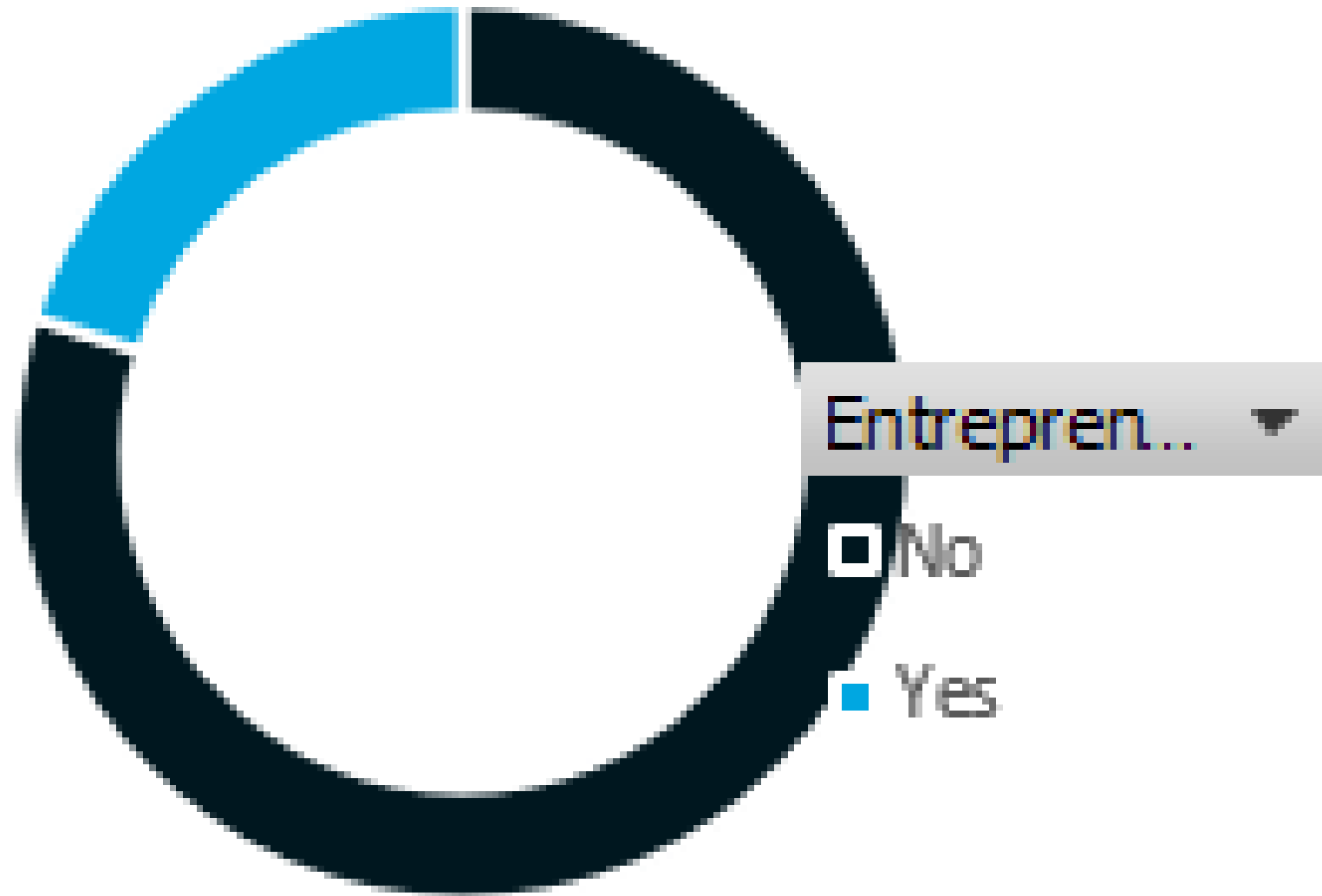
Career sat. & Job level



Visual: Bar chart showing career satisfaction levels across different job levels: Entry, Mid, Executive, and Senior. Satisfaction appears to be highest at the Mid-level in this visualization.

Note: Career satisfaction seems to vary across different job levels, with the Mid-level showing the highest average satisfaction in this data

% Entrp. vs. non Entrp.



Entrepreneurial status

- Visual: Donut chart showing the percentage of "Yes" (entrepreneurs) and "No" (non-entrepreneurs). The "No" segment is significantly larger than the "Yes" segment, visually representing the 80% vs. 20% split.
- Note: This chart visually reinforces that a larger proportion (80%) of the individuals in this dataset did not become entrepreneurs, compared to the 20% who did.

KEY INSIGHTS

- Academic success doesn't guarantee career satisfaction.
Good Grades $\neq$ Career Readiness: Some high performers lacked practical exposure like internships or career training — a gap that may hinder real-world success
- Students with high GPA comes from different field of studies
-
- Career readiness (soft skills + networking) correlates better with job offers.
Internships Matter: Students with at least one internship opportunity had significantly higher employment rates and stronger career outcome
- Computer science and engineering tend to have more certifications and project completion
-
- Career outcome; not all high performance secure jobs immediately.
- Career Support Pays Off: Career guidance and mentorship correlated with better readiness and smoother transitions into the workforce
- Career satisfaction is not always tied to salary or job level.
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- Work-life balance can be low even with high satisfaction—highlighting deeper motivations.
- Some high-satisfaction individuals have lower work-life balance scores



RECOMEDATION

Based on the insights drawn, here are key suggestions moving forward:

- Rethink Success Metrics: Institutions should balance GPA with career preparedness, mental health, and emotional resilience.
- Strengthen Internship Pipelines: Schools must create more real-world learning opportunities to bridge the academic-employment gap.
- Embed Career Coaching: Regular mentorship and career planning should be part of every academic program, not an afterthought.
- Support Holistic Development: Emotional intelligence, financial literacy, and self-management should be integrated into the curriculum.
- Explore Entrepreneurial Training: Including entrepreneurship modules or startup exposure can help students think beyond just employment.

CONCLUSION

While academic excellence is often celebrated, this project reveals that true success in life after school depends on much more than grades.

Factors like internships, mentorship, emotional balance, and career support play critical roles in shaping a graduate's outcome.

This analysis invites students, educators, and stakeholders to rethink what success really looks like — not just in school, but in life. It's a call to widen our focus from scorecards to support systems that empower the whole student.



Thank you for taking the time to explore this project. Whether you're a student, an educator, a policymaker, or someone simply curious — I hope these insights spark reflection and action. Together, we can create a more balanced path to success for every learner.